

Website review

City of Alameda, California

www.alamedaca.gov (home page)

Prepared by Softosync, Karachi | October 11, 2026

This review is based on the public home page and the FAQ page, read on October 11, 2026. It lists only what we could see in the page content. Items we could not measure are marked **to verify**.

1. Summary

The City of Alameda site already does several things well for a city of about 80,000 residents: seven languages, a skip link, current news and a clear accessibility page. The findings below are mostly about **consistency and task-first navigation** rather than visual style. Most can be fixed without changing the CMS (Granicus OpenCities).

Measure	Result	Note
Pages read	Home, FAQ	Full page text and metadata
Issues found	12	1 high, 7 medium, 4 low (section 3)
Strengths noted	7	Section 5
PageSpeed / Lighthouse	Not measured	No report was provided and our environment could not load the site. To verify before any scores are quoted.
Image alt text, mobile layout, schema, broken links, contrast	Not measured	To verify with a browser-based crawl.

2. Evidence from the pages

Screenshots could not be captured from our environment, so the evidence is the page content and metadata as read.

Observation	Where	What the page shows
Three alert links, two destinations	Menu, Quick Links, footer	Menu: "Alerts & Advisories" goes to /RESIDENTS/Alerts-Advisories. Quick Links "Alerts & Advisories" and footer "Alerts" go to /RESIDENTS/Alameda-Ready.
Same story, two entries	Home: Featured and News	Featured link "Cooling Centers Open Saturday October 3rd" and News item "Cooling Centers Open During Heat Wave" (Oct 5) are separate pages.
Generic title and heading	Home	Title: "HOME | City of Alameda". Page heading: "HOME".
Metadata gap	Home vs. FAQ	The FAQ page carries a description and a preview image. The home page metadata returned had neither.
2020 notice in page content	Home and FAQ	"Street Sweeping Scheduled ... Monday, June 15, 2020", followed by an empty "Announcement" block linking to "Copy-of-Public-Works-1".
Repeated menu items	Main menu	"New Resident Guide" under Residents twice. "Making Alameda Accessible (ADA)" under Residents and Citywide Projects.
17 RFPs inside a menu	Business > Bid on City Contracts	17 individual bid pages listed as sub-items, one title cut off ("...Fire Sprinkler Sys").

3. Issues and fixes

Priority	Area	Problem	Fix
High	Alerts	Alert links lead to two different pages (Alerts-Advisories and Alameda-Ready).	Pick one canonical alerts page, link every entry point to it, and redirect the other.
Medium	Content	Featured card and News item cover the same cooling-center notice on two URLs; one title names a date (Oct 3) that has passed.	One page per notice with an updated title; Featured and News should point to the same URL.
Medium	SEO / sharing	Home page metadata returned no description and no preview image, unlike the FAQ page. To verify in a browser.	Add a plain-language description and a 1200 px preview image so links shared by text or social show properly.
Medium	Title / headings	Title "HOME | City of Alameda" and heading "HOME" say nothing about the site.	Title such as "City of Alameda: services, news and meetings"; a descriptive H1.
Medium	Stale content	A June 15, 2020 street sweeping notice and an empty "Announcement" block sit in the page content of Home and FAQ. May be hidden: to verify visually.	Remove the block, or confirm it is not rendered.
Medium	Navigation	Two menu items appear in two branches each (New Resident Guide, Making Alameda Accessible).	Keep one home for each page and cross-link from the other.
Medium	Navigation	17 RFP pages are listed inside the Business menu.	Show "Bid on City contracts" as one item leading to a filterable list with status and due date.
Medium	Task flow	Twelve Quick Links in one flat list: agendas, Report a Problem, records, alerts, departments, police, recreation, passports, shuttle, weddings, jobs, permits.	Group by task (Report, Pay, Apply, Find) and feature the four most used.
Low	Labels	Years in permanent labels: "Local Campaigns 2025", "Proclamations 2026", "10th Annual Job Fair" registration.	Evergreen labels; move dated items to News or Events.
Low	Links	Quick Link "City Meeting Agendas" and the FAQ hazardous waste link use http://.	Use https links throughout.
Low	FAQ page	Still introduced as questions about "the new website". Links read "Click here"; the parking ticket answer is a raw ID-style URL; the calendar answer points to a different page than the footer Calendar.	Rewrite for current visitors, use descriptive link text, use readable URLs.
Low	Feedback	"Report Website Errors" is a mailto link to one named staff mailbox, with that address as the subject.	Use a short feedback form or a shared inbox.

4. UI review

Hierarchy. The home page lists Featured, News, Events, Elected Officials and "Alameda by the numbers" in sequence. The services people come for (report, pay, apply) sit in the Quick Links block rather than leading the page.

Wayfinding. Navigation mixes audience groups (Residents, Business), topics (Citywide Projects) and structure (Your Government). A visitor with a task has to guess which group holds it. A search-first hero with task groups removes the guess.

Visual identity. The page uses a light grey theme with the city logo. The island setting, the Estuary and the ferry and water shuttle are strong local motifs that the demo uses as one illustration.

To verify: mobile layout, tap target sizes, colour contrast, keyboard order and the image alt text count.

5. Strengths

1. Seven interface languages: English, Spanish, Chinese, Tagalog, Vietnamese, Korean, Arabic.
2. A skip-to-content link on every page.
3. A dedicated Accessibility & ADA page and an accommodation request form in the footer.
4. Report a Problem (SeeClickFix) is a prominent Quick Link.
5. News and events are current (October 2026), and the copyright year is 2026.
6. Ballot information (Measure L) is featured with FAQ and project list pages.
7. A public phone directory is linked from every footer.

6. Four-week action plan

Week	Focus	Outcome
1	Quick wins in the current CMS	One alerts destination, remove the 2020 notice, fix title and H1, add description and preview image, https links.
2	Navigation clean-up	Remove duplicate menu entries, move 17 RFPs to one filterable page, evergreen labels.
3	Task-first home page	Search-first hero, Quick Links grouped by task, single cooling-center page.
4	Check and hand over	Mobile and accessibility test, PageSpeed baseline and re-test, staff notes.

7. Demo

A working home page demo built only from content on alamedaca.gov: softosync.github.io/client-demos/city-of-alameda/. It is marked as a demonstration and hidden from search engines. The island scene is an illustration; the live site's photographs would replace it. Links stay inside the demo.

8. Next steps

We propose a 30-minute online call to walk through this review and the demo. Work can be phased: quick fixes first, then navigation, then the home page. Pricing follows after the call.

Muhammad Zain, Founder, Softosync
softosync.com | zain@softosync.com | support@softosync.com | +92 308 2615761 (phone and WhatsApp)
Portfolio: softosync.com/portfolio